

Epicenter of Chaos

(Elfona's POV)

Tyrants rule with an iron fist. It is a universal constant, something the **First Hero** claimed to despise in the ancient texts. Yet, the entity currently occupying the throne—the person who just casually launched a moon-sized fireball into the stratosphere—laughed. It wasn't the laugh of a savior; it was the amused, satanic chuckle of a god testing a new toy. To him, that cataclysm was just "learning basic spells."

To us, it was a declaration of the end times.

I stood on the balcony, the residual heat of his magic still prickling against my skin. The political landscape was shifting as violently as the tectonic plates beneath us. The **Vampire Faction** was already moving, their mobilization aggressive and unchecked. They were overpowering the Elf Faction not through diplomacy, but through the sheer weight of implied violence.

And why wouldn't they? They knew the odds. In a world governed by power, having the **First Hero** as their "Ace in the Hole" gave them a 100% probability of victory. But victory for the Vampires meant subjugation for the Elves. They wouldn't just conquer us; they would draft my brethren into their mindless wars across the planet, using our mana to fuel their expansion until we were extinct.

"I have decided," I whispered to the wind, my voice hardening. "A being who can command the concept of Death itself will not die from a single spell. I cannot stop him... but perhaps I can balance him."

I closed my eyes and activated my **UNIQUE SKILL: ALL-TRUE SEEKER EYE**.

The world stripped away its color, replaced by lines of mana and threads of fate. My vision expanded, shooting across the continent, scanning signatures. I wasn't looking for a god. I was looking for the variable. I was looking for **Jerry**.

Target Located.

He was deep in the Infinite Desert, standing near the **Temple of Ancient Wisdom**. My breath hitched. That temple was built by the **Titan of Information**, a relic from the Age of Myths. It was a site the **Second Hero (Sana)** had visited frequently in the past. Legends whispered that within those walls lay the only knowledge capable of slaying the First Hero.

"Perfect," I said, my resolve solidifying into action.

I didn't waste a second. I channeled mana into my legs and back, activating **FEATHERLESS FLIGHT**.

It wasn't true flight—elves were not birds, and we did not possess wings. This was physics. I compressed the air behind me, creating a high-pressure zone while simultaneously lowering the air resistance in front of me. The result was a violent propulsion, pushing my body forward akin to a jet engine.

Boom.

I launched from the balcony, the sonic boom silenced instantly by my secondary spell: **NATURE MAGIC: OPTICAL REFRACTION**. I bent the light around my form, rendering myself invisible to the naked eye and dampening my thermal signature.

As I hurtled toward the desert at Mach speeds, the wind screaming against my barrier, my mind raced. The only way to stop this endless war wasn't to kill Charlie. It was to find someone who could stand next to him.

If I could guide Jerry to the Holy Empire... if I could teach this new hero to prove himself... perhaps then, Lord First would find something he hadn't had in eons: a true friend. An equal.

Only an equal could quell the boredom of a god. Without that, we were all just ants waiting to be burned under his magnifying glass.

"Wait for me, Jerry," I thought, watching the golden dunes approach on the horizon. "The fate of the world depends on you becoming strong enough to survive a handshake with a monster."

(Jerry's POV)

The Infinite Desert lived up to its name. It was a hellscape of shifting silicon and scorching solar radiation. My **Nature Magic** barrier filtered out the UV rays, but the heat was a physical weight, pressing against my mana reserves.

Ahead, the **Temple of Ancient Wisdom** rose from the dunes like a skeletal hand reaching for the heavens. It was a ruin of black basalt, untouched by the erosion of time.

"Great," I muttered, shielding my eyes from the sudden sandstorm whipping up from nowhere. "Just as I was figuring out the thermal conductivity of this basalt."

I didn't need a sensor to tell me who just landed. The mana signature was dense, green, and smelled like ozone and crushed petals. I braced myself.

BOOM.

The impact sent a shockwave of sand and compressed air rippling outward. I coughed, checking my **Index of Magic**. My mana was hovering at a pathetic 23%.

"Elfona," I whispered, stepping back. "What is the Queen of the Elven Faction doing in a mid-level grinding zone?"

The dust settled, revealing her floating slightly off the ground, her immaculate robes untouched by the grime.

"Well, I don't know what you mean by 'grinding zone,' but I am glad that the **Infinite Blades** have barely left a scratch on your lovely humor," Elfona said, a faint smile touching her lips. "And I also see that you are no longer scared to speak your mind in front of me."

My stomach tightened at the mention of the Blades. "Still, my question stands. Why are you here? Sent by Charlie to finish what he couldn't?"

I shifted my stance, my feet digging into the hot sand. I was looking for a way out, calculating vectors. I didn't know if I could survive another **Death Attack** or if his last move was a one-time trump card.

"I am here to help you," Elfona said earnestly.

My face must have betrayed my confusion because she sighed, descending slightly. "It does have mutual benefits. Close by is the Temple of Wisdom. Rumors suggest there lies a power—or knowledge—which could defeat, or at least match, the First Hero."

"I don't understand," I said, shaking my head. "Lord First is your beloved ruler. He is the God of this world. Why do you want to go against such a person?"

"Because he is planning to start ceaseless wars across the planet to expand our country more," Elfona said, her voice tinged with irritation. "He is bored, Jerry. And a bored god is a calamity."

She took a step forward, hand extended.

"Sorry," I said, my voice dropping. "I've had enough of betrayals for a lifetime."

As I spoke, I wasn't just standing there. I was pouring my remaining mana into the sand beneath Elfona's feet. I wasn't casting a spell; I was rearranging the periodic table.

I transmuted the Silica (SiO_2) into a volatile mixture of Potassium Nitrate, Carbon, and Sulfur.

Gunpowder.

And for the detonator? I stripped the chloride ions from the salt in the sand, leaving behind pure, unstable **Sodium**.

"You better don't," Elfona warned, her eyes narrowing as she sensed the mana flux.

"Too late," I grinned. "**ALCHEMICAL IGNITION.**"

The Sodium reacted with the moisture in the air instantly.

KABOOM.

The desert floor erupted. A pillar of black smoke and fire blasted upward, turning the sand into glass instantly.

I shielded my face, coughing in the smoke. "That should at least buy me a..."

I froze.

Twenty, maybe thirty feet in the air, Elfona stood on a platform of compressed wind. She looked down at me, her clothes unruffled, her expression one of pity rather than anger. She hadn't just dodged; she had ascended before the chemical reaction could even propagate.

It was a vertical leap that defied gravity, telling me one thing clearly: I was not on her level.

"I knew I was stuck," I muttered to myself, the smoke clearing around my defeat. "But I can't trust someone whose life is centered around serving my murderer."